

Brunei



Lying on the northern coast of the island of Borneo, Brunei is surrounded and divided in two by the Malaysian state of Sarawak. It has been independent since 1984.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly dense lowland rainforest and mangrove swamps, with some mountains in the southeast.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Six-month rainy season with very high humidity.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Malays benefit from positive discrimination. Many in the Chinese community are stateless. Since a failed rebellion in 1962, Brunei has been ruled by decree of the sultan. In 1990, "Malay Muslim Monarchy" was introduced, promoting Islamic values as state ideology. Women, less restricted than in some Muslim states, usually wear headscarves but not the veil.



INSIGHT: *The sultan spent US\$350 million building the world's largest palace at Bandar Seri Begawan*



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas production has brought one of the world's highest standards of living. Massive overseas investments. Major consumer of high-tech hi-fi, video equipment, and Western designer clothes.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Sultanate of Brunei

DATE OF FORMATION: 1984

CAPITAL: Bandar Seri Begawan

POPULATION: 399,700

TOTAL AREA: 2228 sq. miles
(5770 sq. km)

DENSITY: 196 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Malay*, English, Chinese

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 66%, Buddhist 14%, other 10%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Malay 67%, Chinese 16%, other 11%, indigenous 6%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Brunei dollar = 100 cents